

On hybrid verb classes: The view from *meal* verbs in Romance

JOSEP AUSENSI^{1*}  and ANNA PINEDA² 

¹ Universitat d'Alacant, Spain

² Universitat de Barcelona, Spain

Received: January 26, 2025 • Revised manuscript received: February 27, 2025 • Accepted: February 27, 2025



© 2025 The Author(s)

ABSTRACT

This paper analyzes the behavior of *meal* verbs in Romance, i.e., *have lunch/breakfast/dinner*, a verb class which we observe shows apparently contradictory behavior in the syntactic diagnostics broadly used to distinguish between unergative and unaccusative verbs. Building on Pineda & Berro's (2020) proposal for Basque, we argue *meal* verbs in Romance involve a hybrid syntactic structure: their subject is associated with more than one distinct functional head and is therefore thematically interpreted as a hybrid subject since it is assigned both an agent/initiator and a patient/undergoer thematic role. We show our proposal is able to account for the discrepancies attested by *meal* verbs when subjected to diagnostics that probe for unergative and unaccusative properties and the distinct syntactic properties this verb class exhibits when compared to their equivalents in Old Romance.

KEYWORDS

syntax, argument structure, external argument, internal argument, agent, patient, (Old) Romance

1. INTRODUCTION

An influential view within syntactic decomposition approaches to verb meaning (cf. D'Alessandro et al. 2017), which posit that verbs are built in the syntax by merging lexical items commonly referred to as roots with verbalizing functional heads such as little *v*, argues that the subject of transitive and unergative verbs is introduced externally to VP. This assumption is due

* Corresponding author. E-mail: Josep.ausensi@ua.es

to Kratzer (1996) who, drawing on a previous original observation in Marantz (1984), proposed that the subject of these verb classes is introduced in the specifier position of a Voice projection, above the VP domain. Kratzer's approach sparked great interest, and since her proposal in the 1990s, several other works have been put forward further claiming that the external argument is not always introduced uniformly by the same functional projection in the verbal domain, i.e., by Voice, as originally proposed by Kratzer. More specifically, these works argue in favor of a view where distinct classes of external arguments can be differentiated depending on the syntactic position they are generated in (e.g., Alexiadou 2014; Tollan 2018; Tollan & Oxford 2018). Main evidence in this respect has generally come from observing that external arguments appear to show distinct syntactic and semantic properties. This line of work proposes that this variation can be accounted for if external arguments are not introduced uniformly, so they are predicted to show distinct grammatical properties as they can be assigned different thematic roles depending on the functional head that introduces them. More recently, Pineda & Berro (2020) and Ausensi & Bigolin (2024) have built on this line of work by arguing in favor of what Pineda & Berro originally called *hybrid verbs*, i.e., verbs whose subjects are claimed to show mixed thematic properties related to external and internal argument properties. As Pineda & Berro discuss in detail for Basque, the term *hybrid* further underscores the fact that these verb classes test positive for both unergativity and unaccusativity when subjected to canonical diagnostics that probe for the presence of external and internal arguments. Proposing a hybrid syntactic structure therefore provides a natural answer as to why these verb classes should show apparently contradictory results in the relevant diagnostics that distinguish unergative from unaccusative verbs.

In this paper, we provide further evidence in favor of the view as originally proposed in the work of Pineda & Berro (2020), and later in Ausensi & Bigolin (2024), regarding the existence of *hybrid verb classes*, i.e., verb classes that show hybrid behavior regarding their status as unergative or unaccusative verbs. More specifically, we concern ourselves with the morphosyntactic variation observed in several Romance languages, mainly Catalan, Spanish, and French, and their respective Old Romance variants, with regards to *meal* verbs, i.e., the Romance translational equivalents of the English verbs *have breakfast*, *have lunch* and *have dinner*, i.e., what Levin (1993, 216) calls *dine* verbs in English, which are “verbs [that] refer to eating particular meals”.¹ We observe *meal* verbs show apparently contradictory results in the syntactic diagnostics that are broadly used to distinguish between unergative and unaccusative verbs. Further, their subject shows hybrid behavior between an external and an internal argument as it involves an agentive subject which is interpreted as an affected argument as well. We assume Pineda & Berro (2020)'s analysis originally proposed for some Basque verbs and suggest that *meal* verbs in Romance involve a hybrid syntax, which is why this verb class tests positive for both unergativity and unaccusativity. Namely, we propose their subject is associated with more than one functional head in the verbal domain and is therefore assigned a dual theta role of agent/initiator and patient/undergoer at the same time. Our analysis therefore provides a natural answer as to why

¹Levin (1993, 216) originally uses the label *dine* verbs for the class of verbs of ingesting that we concern ourselves with in this paper. We have opted to refer to this class of verbs of ingesting as *meal* verbs instead, since we believe the label *meal* is more transparent in order to refer to the fact that these verbs denote events of eating meals, as Levin (1993) herself discusses.

meal verbs in Romance should show apparently contradictory behavior when subjected to canonical diagnostics that probe for the presence of external and internal arguments.

We proceed as follows. Section 2 provides a brief overview of recent works that propose that intransitive verbs can be classified into more groups than just two, advocating in turn for the existence of further distinctions beyond unaccusatives and unergatives. Section 3 analyzes the behavior of *meal* verbs across Romance languages on the basis of a number of well-established syntactic diagnostics regarding unaccusativity and unergativity. We observe that *meal* verbs sometimes behave like unergatives and in other cases like unaccusatives. We propose that *meal* verbs in Romance involve a hybrid argument structure in which their subject is interpreted as an agentive initiator and a sentient affected argument at the same time. Section 4 concludes.

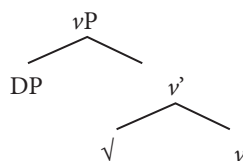
2. THE CLASSIFICATION OF INTRANSITIVE VERBS

Since the end of the 1970s, intransitive verbs have been generally classified into the two major classes of unergative and unaccusative verbs (Perlmutter 1978, 1989; Perlmutter & Postal 1984; Burzio 1981, 1986; Sorace 2000, among many others). The most important distinction between these two verb classes is related to the properties of their only argument. In unergative verbs, the subject shows more agent-like properties, whereas the subject of unaccusative verbs behaves more like an object and shows properties typical of patients (cf. Levin & Rappaport Hovav 1995). In Romance languages, unaccusative verbs have been observed to show certain special properties. To name a few examples, Romance unaccusative verbs, in contrast to unergative verbs, can form prenominal adjectival participles (Bresnan 1982; Levin & Rappaport 1986), can have their subject cliticized with *ne* in Italian or *en* in Catalan (Solà 1973; Burzio 1986; Rigau 1990; Levin & Rappaport Hovav 1995), allow bare subjects in post-verbal position (Perlmutter 1978; Burzio 1986; Belletti 1988, 1999; Torrego 1989; Rigau 1990; Cifuentes Honrubia 1999; Mateu & Massanell i Messalles 2015) and, in Romance languages with auxiliary alternation, e.g., Italian, French, generally combine with *BE*, instead of *HAVE* (cf. Sorace 2000).²

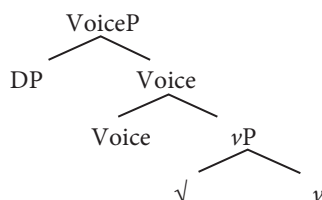
In the generative grammar tradition, unergative and unaccusative verbs have been analyzed as involving two different syntactic structures (cf. Burzio 1981, 1986). Unaccusative verbs consist of a sole subject argument which is VP internal, whereas unergatives have their subject introduced externally to VP. Cashing out this proposal in the tradition of Distributed Morphology (cf. Halle & Marantz 1993), where verbs are assumed to be combinations of so-called roots and verbalizing functional heads such as the little *v* head, unergative and unaccusative verbs can be given the following syntactic representations illustrated below in (1). These structures can account for the proposal back in the 1970s that the subjects of unergative and unaccusatives have distinct syntactic properties. Namely, the subject of unaccusative verbs is introduced *v*P internally (1a) and is therefore predicted to show object-like behavior since it qualifies as a proper internal argument. In contrast, the subject of unergative verbs qualifies as an external argument as it is introduced externally to the *v*P (1b), in the specifier position of the Voice projection, which assigns an agent theta role to it (cf. Kratzer 1996).

²For descriptive ease, we use *BE/HAVE* in small capital letters as a placeholder for the variants of the auxiliary verbs in each of the relevant Romance languages that show a split auxiliary system for compound tenses.

(1) a. Unaccusative verbs

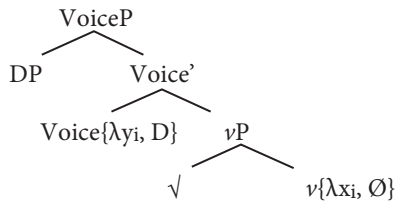


b. Unergative verbs



This binary classification, however, has been called into question given that not all intransitive verbs in all languages apparently behave as neatly falling into one group or another. To name a few examples, Kural (2002) proposes a four-way classification of intransitive verbs in order to explain the discrepancies observed in diagnostics like *there*-insertion, locative inversion, and/or null causativization. Several other works have refined the configuration of unaccusatives and suggested that they can be of more than one type depending on the specifier position the subject is introduced in (e.g., Alexiadou & Anagnostopoulou 2004; Alexiadou & Schäfer 2011; Irwin 2012; Alexiadou 2014; Copley & Harley 2015). The uniformity of unergative verbs has also been called into question. For instance, Tollan (2018) has recently suggested that the subject of unergative verbs in Samoan, an ergative language, is introduced differently than the subject of transitive verbs. Unergative verbs have their subjects introduced in the specifier position of ν P, whereas the subjects of transitives are introduced by Voice (see also Wood 2012; Nash 2020; Öztürk 2020). More recently, Pineda & Berro (2020) have proposed that the single subject argument of intransitive verbs may not always be regarded as a canonical external or internal argument. Pineda & Berro focus on a group of verbs in Basque consisting of a single agentive argument that is also claimed to be interpreted as an affected argument, e.g., *bazkaldu* ‘have lunch’, *solastatu* ‘talk’, *borrokatu* ‘fight’. Pineda & Berro argue that these verbs are *hybrid* in the sense that their subject is associated with more than one functional head in the syntax and is therefore thematically interpreted as both the agent/initiator of the action these verbs denote and the patient/undergoer of that action at the same time (see also Ausensi & Bigolin 2024). All these proposals share the core idea that intransitive verbs cannot be categorically divided into a twofold classification in terms of unergativity or unaccusativity in which subjects behave as proper external or internal arguments.

In the present paper, we analyze the behavior of *meal* verbs across Romance languages on the basis of a number of well-established syntactic diagnostics regarding unaccusativity and unergativity. We note that *meal* verbs sometimes behave like unergatives and in other cases like unaccusatives. In order to account for their hybrid behavior, we follow Pineda & Berro (2020) in proposing that *meal* verbs in Romance involve a *hybrid syntax* in which their subject has mixed thematic properties between an agent/initiator and a patient/undergoer. More specifically, we propose that the subject of *meal* verbs in Romance is generated in the specifier position of Voice and is coindexed with the non-pronounced specifier of the thematic but syntactically intransitive ν head (2) (cf. Schäfer 2008; Alexiadou, Anagnostopoulou & Schäfer 2015; Pineda & Berro 2020).

(2) Proposed structure for *meal* verbs in Romance

As we observe in the discussion to follow, the subject of *meal* verbs generally patterns with external arguments when tested with standard diagnostics that probe for the presence of external and internal arguments. This is expected in our approach since the subject is initially externally merged in the specifier position of Voice. However, its syntactic behavior also diverges from canonical external arguments in certain respects, underscoring its dual role. In our account, this duality is encoded in the syntax by means of coindexation, which has both syntactic and semantic implications. Specifically, while the subject is externally merged in VoiceP, it is also linked to a non-pronounced specifier in *v*P, where it receives an undergoer/patient role. This structural configuration accounts for the subject's hybrid behavior, as it simultaneously exhibits properties of both external and internal arguments.

Before moving forward, we wish to stress that the specific syntactic implementation of the dual representation of the subject of *meal* verbs is not the central issue; rather, what matters is that the subject is syntactically represented in two distinct positions within the thematic domain, however this is formally implemented. In this respect, as an anonymous reviewer notes, the fact that *meal* verbs appear to be denominal across languages suggests that the syntax underlying these constructions may play a role in their hybrid behavior. More specifically, the reviewer notes that it is likely that the dual representation of the subject in the syntax of constructions with *meal* verbs is a consequence (directly or indirectly) of the non-verbal syntax that underlies these constructions. Namely, English constructions such as *he had his breakfast/lunch/dinner* explicitly represent the subject twice: as the subject of *have*—a verb that can take non-agentive subjects (e.g., *he had a fit/seizure/stroke*)—and as the possessor of the meal-denoting nominal. This suggests that the apparent hybrid nature of *meal* verbs across languages could stem, at least in part, from the interaction between verbal and non-verbal syntax. For the Romance languages examined here, what is crucial is that the hybrid syntax accounts for both the agentive and undergoer thematic interpretations of the subject of *meal* verbs. For simplicity, we follow the analysis in [Pineda & Berro \(2020\)](#), as it accounts for similar data, while acknowledging that alternative analyses remain possible.

3. MEAL VERBS IN ROMANCE

The *meal* verbs we concern ourselves with here are the translational equivalents of the English verbs *have breakfast*, *have lunch* and *have dinner* (cf. [Levin 1993](#) on *dine* verbs in English). Essentially, we propose that this verb class in Romance behaves as internally caused change of state verbs of the *bloom* or *wilt* type in English (cf. [Levin & Rappaport Hovav 1995](#); [Alexiadou 2014](#); [Rappaport Hovav 2020](#)). However, *meal* verbs are different in that their subject qualifies as an agentive entity and mostly behaves as an external argument when subjected to relevant

diagnostics that probe for agenthood/unergativity. On our analysis, in an example involving a *meal* verb as in Spanish *Juan desayunó* ‘Juan had breakfast’, the subject argument *Juan* volitionally initiates an action of manipulating food which leads to ingesting the meal and experiencing the process at the same time (cf. Jerro 2019). Our proposal then shares some key aspects with the analysis in Jerro (2019) for verbs of ingesting in Lubukusu, e.g., a verb like *khu-lia* ‘eat’ is given an event structure where the subject is an agent that acts as the manipulator of the food as well as the agent of the change of state. Essentially, both our proposal and Jerro’s share the intuition that the subject of these verbs involves properties of both agents/initiators and patients/undergoers. Romance *meal* verbs of the Spanish *desayunar* sort can therefore be given a paraphrase along the lines of *intentionally stop fasting by ingesting food* (Cremades & Ginebra 2021a, 2021b). Crucially, however, we note that *stop fasting* is grammatically represented as a proper change of state process, since *meal* verbs in Romance can occur in constructions that only allow verbs entailing result states predicated of an internal argument such as resultative adjectival participles, e.g., *The vase is broken* (cf. Embick 2004). This is relevant insofar as participles built on canonical unergative verbs are categorically disallowed as there is no possible result state interpretation of an internal argument, as unergative verbs generally encode a type of action with no entailment that a result state follows from said action (cf. Rappaport Hovav & Levin 1998). Namely, on our account, the fact that a resultative adjectival participle can be built on *meal* verbs as in Spanish *Los niños están desayunados/cenados* lit. ‘The kids are breakfasted/dined’ in contrast to resultative adjectival participles built on canonical unergative verbs, e.g., **Los niños están trabajados/sonreídos* lit. ‘The kids are worked/laughed’ (cf. Embick 2004) receives a straightforward explanation since the subject of *meal* verbs is thematically interpreted as both an agent/initiator and as a patient/undergoer, as it is an argument of both Voice and little *v* and is therefore predicted to show apparently contradictory behavior when subjected to unaccusativity and unergativity diagnostics.

In what follows, we analyze the behavior of *meal* verbs across Romance languages and subject them to several syntactic diagnostics that are commonly assumed to probe for the presence of external and internal arguments. We mainly draw our data from Catalan, Spanish and French, and their respective Old Romance variants, but occasionally refer to other Romance languages such as Portuguese, Italian or Occitan.³ The diagnostics we concern ourselves with are (i) ability to take measuring direct objects, (ii) compatibility with the reflexive pronoun *se*, (iii) auxiliary selection in compound tenses and (iv) occurrence as resultative adjectival participles. As we discuss, these diagnostics are relevant since in Romance, an unergative verb with a canonical agent argument as its subject can generally take measuring direct objects, it is not marked with *se*, selects HAVE in compound tenses and does not occur as a resultative adjectival participle. In contrast, unaccusative verbs generally behave quite differently as they do not take measuring direct objects, can be marked with *se*, take BE in compound tenses and can occur as resultative adjectival participles. As we show, *meal* verbs in Romance generate apparently contradictory results in these diagnostics. We suggest this is due to this verb class involving both unergative-like and unaccusative-like properties owing to their hybrid syntax, that is, a configuration where the subject has both external and internal argument properties. We start by considering measuring direct objects and then move on to the rest of diagnostics.

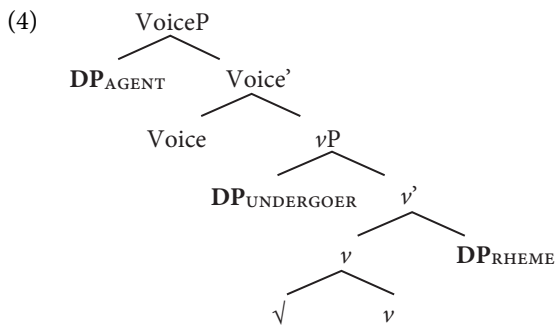
³The sources we consulted to extract the relevant examples we provide in this paper can be found at the end of the paper, in a section called *Sources*.

3.1. Measuring direct objects

Unergative verbs are generally compatible with direct objects that measure out the event denoted by the verb, as shown by the English examples below (see Tenny 1987, 1994; Hale & Keyser 1997, 2002). For instance, in (3a), the development of the event can be tracked by observing the progress of the eating of the pear; similar comments apply to (3b) and (3c).

- (3) a. John ate a pear.
 b. Freddy sang Bohemian Rhapsody.
 c. Tom danced a tango.

As mentioned above, we assume that Voice and v introduce the initiator and undergoer theta roles respectively. When they are syntactically introduced, each argument occupies the specifier position of its corresponding functional head. Regarding measuring direct objects like the ones above, we follow Ramchand (2008), who calls them *rhemes*, and assume that they are introduced in the complement position of the functional head which also introduces the undergoer, v in (4).



vP can in principle host two arguments: an undergoer and a rhematic argument. However, only one can receive structural case from Voice. We assume nominative and accusative case are assigned by T and Voice respectively, and that, updating Burzio's generalization (1986), Voice only assigns case if it has an unvalued D feature (Pesetsky & Torrego 2004). This means that only verbs whose subject is introduced syntactically in the specifier of Voice will be able to have accusative-marked vP -internal arguments. In unergative verbs like *sing* or *dance* (3), their subjects are introduced outside vP , in the specifier of Voice (Kratzer 1996), and therefore get nominative case from T. Given that Voice has a D feature in this case (cf. (2)), Voice can assign accusative case. Consequently, the subject of unergatives can co-occur with another case-marked argument within the vP , which gives rise to a transitive configuration, as illustrated by the examples above in (3). The subject of unaccusative verbs, in contrast, is introduced within vP (cf. (1b)). Voice in this case does not have a D feature, and as a consequence, unaccusative subjects need to be case marked (with nominative) by T and are not compatible with another overt object introduced within vP as it would require structural case from Voice.

If we apply this analysis to *meal* verbs in Romance, we expect them to permit measuring direct objects, since we propose that they involve a hybrid syntax with their subjects originally

introduced in the specifier position of Voice (2). In the Romance languages studied, at first blush we observe two different patterns, with French and Catalan on one side, and Spanish on the other. In Standard French, *meal* verbs do not allow measuring objects (5), so that the expression of what is eaten needs to resort to a paraphrasis (6) or a PP-complement (7)–(8) (Cremades & Ginebra 2021a).

- (5) *déjeuner/dîner **quelque chose.**
 have.lunch/dinner.INF some thing
 ‘to eat something for lunch/dinner.’
- (6) manger **quelque chose** pour déjeuner/dîner.
 eat.INF some thing for lunch/dinner.INF
 ‘to eat something for lunch/dinner.’
- (7) déjeuner/dîner **avec ou de quelque chose.**
 have.lunch/dinner.INF with or of something
 ‘to have lunch/dinner with or of something.’
- (8) *Trésor*, s.v. *déjeuner, dîner*
- a. des gamines [...] déjeuner dans l’ école avec des **œufs**
 PART kids have.lunch.GER in the school with PART eggs
 durs.
 boiled
 ‘kids [...] having boiled eggs for lunch at school.’
- b. Ils dînèrent **d’ un potage à l’ huile.**
 they dine.PST.3PL of a soup to the oil
 ‘They ate an oil soup for dinner.’

The fact that Standard French apparently does not allow measuring direct objects might suggest that *meal* verbs in this Romance language need not necessarily involve a hybrid argument structure, as we have been proposing, with their subject originally introduced in the specifier position of Voice, and co-indexed with the non-pronounced specifier of *v* (2). Upon closer inspection, however, *meal* verbs in French can appear with measuring direct objects, especially in informal contexts.⁴ For instance, French speakers we consulted report to us that although it appears to be the case that *déjeuner/dîner* ‘have lunch/dinner’ are not generally used in their

⁴The same picture has been reported to us for Italian, where *pranzare/cenare* ‘have lunch/dinner’ are generally intransitive (see fn. 8), but in informal conversations, it is possible to find them with a measuring direct object:

(i) **Cos’** hai cenato?
 what have.PRS.2SG dine.PTCP
 ‘What have you had for dinner?’

(Alessandro Bigolin, p.c.)

transitive variant, *petit-déjeuner* ‘have breakfast’ behaves differently since transitive instances of this *meal* verb in French frequently occur.

- (9) Le matin je petit-déjeune deux tartines de confiture
 the morning I have.breakfast.PRS.1SG two toasts of jam
 et un café.
 and a coffee
 ‘In the morning, I have two toasts with jam and coffee for breakfast.’
 (Marc Olivier-Loiseau, p.c.)

Similarly, as Cremades & Ginebra (2021a) observe, although *dîner* and *déjeuner* are mostly used intransitively in Standard French, with a PP introducing the meal that is ingested, as illustrated above (7)–(8), there are naturally occurring data of these *meal* verbs taking a measuring direct object, especially in informal contexts, as illustrated by the examples provided below, which frequently occur on the web.

- (10) a. Ce soir, je dîne un steak et du homard.
 this evening I have.dinner.PRS.1SG a steak and PART lobster
 ‘This evening, I have a steak and lobster for dinner.’
 b. Le soir je dîne un poisson au barbecue
 the evening I have.dinner.PRS.1SG a fish in.the barbecue
 avec une bière
 with a beer
 ‘In the evening, I have a barbecued fish and a beer for dinner’
 c. Je déjeuner un oeuf mollet mais avec du pain.
 I have.lunch.PRS.1SG an egg soft-boiled but with PART bread
 ‘I have a soft-boiled egg for lunch but with bread.’
 (Web)

The variation exhibited by *meal* verbs in French might be due to the fact that *déjeuner* and *dîner* are slowly becoming archaic in use in favor of *manger* ‘eat’, and they are not as frequently used as *petit-déjeuner* ‘have breakfast’. In any case, it seems reasonable to conclude that measuring direct objects in French are ultimately possible, as they are freely available with *petit-déjeuner*, and also occur with *déjeuner* and *dîner*. *Meal* verbs in French can be thus said to involve the same hybrid syntactic structure as Spanish and Catalan, especially since French patterns like Spanish and Catalan in the rest of diagnostics we employ, as we discuss in detail in the next sections.

Turning now to Catalan, *meal* verbs have been traditionally considered intransitives as well (*DIEC2*, *DCVB*), so that a paraphrasis must be used to express what is eaten, as in Standard French.

- (11) a. Per esmorzar hem menjat pa amb oli.
 for breakfast have.PRS.1PL eat.PTCP bread with oil
 ‘We had bread with oil for breakfast.’

- b. Què menjareu **per** **dinar**?
 what eat.FUT.2PL for lunch
 'What will you eat for lunch?'

Nowadays, however, speakers accept and make use of measuring objects with this verb class quite freely and naturally, especially in Barcelona and Valencian Catalan. This view can be confirmed by the fact that *meal* verbs in Catalan frequently occur with measuring direct objects in corpora and do not sound marked or unnatural to native speakers (cf. Cremades & Ginebra 2021b).⁵

(12) *DCVB*, s.v. *dinar*, *sopar*

- a. Què has dinat avui?
 what have.PRS.2SG have.lunch.PTCP today
 'What did you have for lunch today?'
- b. He dinat **arròs**.
 have.PRS.1SG have.lunch.PTCP rice
 'I had rice for lunch.'
- c. Hem sopat **truita de ceba**.
 have.PRS.1PL have.dinner.PTCP omelet of onion
 'We had onion omelet for dinner.'

The picture in Spanish is a bit different in the sense that *meal* verbs in this Romance language are readily compatible with direct objects that measure out the event, as traditional grammars or dictionaries do not classify them as intransitives in the first place.⁶

(13) *DRAE*, s.v. *desayunar*, *almorzar*, *cenar*

- a. Desayuno **un** **café**.
 have.breakfast.1PRS.SG a coffee
 'I have a coffee for breakfast.'
- b. Almorzar **chuletas**.
 have.lunch.INF chops
 'To eat chops for lunch.'

⁵In previous stages of the language, PP complements with *de* 'of' and *ab/amb* 'with' were also often used to express what is eaten, as extensively shown by Cremades & Ginebra (2021c).

⁶The transitive pattern is equally extended in Portuguese with *almorçar*, *lanchar* and *jantar* (see Cremades & Ginebra 2021a, 140–141 and references cited therein). In Italian, the *meal* verbs *pranzare* 'have lunch', *desinare* 'have lunch' and *cenare* 'have dinner' are intransitive and resort to PP paraphrases to express what is eaten, e.g., *mangiare una pizza per cena* 'eat a pizza for dinner'. However, by making use of a survey of the main dictionaries of Italian, Cremades & Ginebra (2021a) (see also Cremades & Ginebra 2021b) point out that they can be used transitively, although such examples nowadays can sound literary or old. These preliminary observations from Italian suggest that there appears to be variation within Romance languages when it comes to *meal* verbs and whether or not they can be categorically classified as belonging to the unergative or unaccusative class, as we discuss.

- c. Cenar **perdices.**
 have.dinner.INF partridges
 ‘To eat partridges for dinner.’

In short, *meal* verbs in Romance test positive for unergativity when it comes to whether they can take measuring direct objects. As discussed in detail at the beginning of this section, this is in fact a welcome prediction of the present account, since we propose that their subject is originally introduced in the specifier position of Voice (2). Namely, we have assumed that only verbs whose subjects are introduced outside *v*P, in the specifier of Voice, can get nominative case from T. In this case, Voice has an unvalued D feature, and it can therefore assign accusative case. This thus makes the prediction that verbs whose subjects are introduced by Voice should permit another case-marked argument within *v*P, giving rise to a transitive configuration (see also [Næss 2011](#)), as the one in (4) above.

The fact that in Standard French and Standard Catalan *meal* verbs have been traditionally considered intransitives by grammars and dictionaries, therefore disallowing direct objects that can measure out the event, might be the result of the fact that this verb class involved more unaccusative properties in Old Romance, whereas in Contemporary Romance they have veered towards a more unergative-like pattern. In the next section, we turn to discuss this possible change in the evolution of *meal* verbs in the history of Romance in more detail.

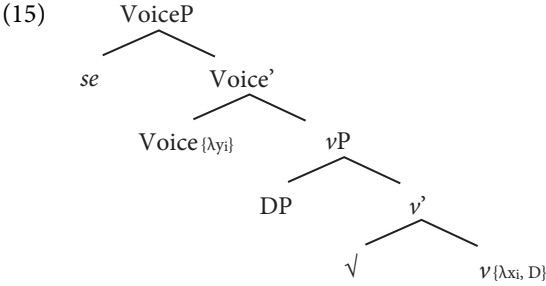
3.2. Compatibility with *se*

A large number of Romance unaccusative verbs feature the reflexive clitic *se*, notably change-of-state unaccusatives entering the so-called causative alternation, as shown for Catalan in (14) (see [Schäfer 2008](#) for an overview of anticausative *se* constructions, i.e., sentences in which *se* marks the unaccusative variant of the causative alternation, as well as [Koontz-Garboden 2009](#)).

- (14) a. La calor ha fos el gelat.
 the heat have.PRS.3SG melt.PTCP the ice-cream
 ‘The heat has melted the ice-cream.’
 b. El gelat s’ ha fos.
 the ice-cream SE have.PRS.3SG melt.PTCP
 ‘The ice-cream has melted.’

An implicative relation can be stated between the presence of *se* and the internal status of the subject: if an intransitive verb is marked with *se*, its subject must be introduced *v*P-internally. Nevertheless, the opposite relation does not hold. As is well known, in Romance, not all unaccusatives or anticausative variants of verbs occur with *se* (or similar “reflexive” clitics). The same picture is found in other languages where anticausatives can be marked or unmarked (e.g., German or Greek). The relation is usually only one-way: it is not the case that the presence or absence of *se* is systematically related to a particular aspectual interpretation across languages ([Alexiadou, Anagnostopoulou & Schäfer 2015](#); also see [MacDonald 2024](#), who argues for the direct aspectual role of the clitic). We partially follow [Schäfer \(2008\)](#) and [Alexiadou, Anagnostopoulou & Schäfer \(2015\)](#) in assuming that the presence of *se* in intransitive clauses is the

consequence of having a Voice head that simply prevents a DP from being projected in the specifier of Voice. Consequently, if an intransitive verb is marked with *se*, it means that its single argument is introduced *vP*-internally, as in (15).⁷



When it comes to *meal* verbs in Romance, it is first important to note that they used to be compatible with the reflexive in Old French and Old Catalan, as shown first in (16) for Old French.⁸

(16) 14th century; *DMF*, s.v. *désjeuner*, *dîner*

- a. Et encores en i avoit biaucop en la ville qui
 and still PART LOC be.IPFV.3SG many in the city who
se desjunoient et buvoient par les taverns.
 REFL have.lunch.IPFV.3PL and drink.IPFV.3PL in the bars
 ‘And still there were many in the city who had lunch and drank in the taverns.’

⁷Alexiadou, Anagnostopoulou & Schäfer (2015) propose that *se* (or non-active verbal morphology in the case of Greek) marks the presence of an expletive Voice head. We assume that *se* is the specifier of a Voice head that introduces an agent/initiator argument—it is thus thematic—but assigns this thematic role the same discourse reference of the argument introduced *vP*-internally.

⁸The same is true for Old Occitan:

(i) 13th century; *Croisade*

- a. Cels de la ost **se dinnan** e mangel carn enrost.
 those of the host REFL dine.PRS.3PL and eat.PRS.3PL meat roasted
 ‘Those of the host dine and eat roasted meat.’
 b. Can **se foron dinnat** et que agron begut.
 when REFL be.PST.3PL dine.PTCP and that have.PST.3PL drink.PTCP
 ‘When they had had dinner and had drunk.’

The Occitan *meal* verb *dinnar/disnar/dirnar* could refer to the main meal of the day (often in the morning) as well as to the evening meal. Due to the various possible meanings of the verb (*have breakfast/lunch/dinner*), we used the English *dine* to convey a ‘neutral’ translation—because the noun *dinner* in English is ambiguous in this way too, at least to refer to either the main meal of the day or the evening meal. At present, Occitan preserves a pronominal *meal* verb, (*es*)*dejuar-se* ‘have breakfast’.

- b. Lequel maistre d' ostel dist à lui qui parle qu'
 which master of hostel say.PST.3SG to him who talk.PRS.3SG that
 ilz **se disneroient** ensamble.
 they REFL have.dinner.COND.3PL together
 'And the master of the hostel told the man who is talking that they would dine together.'

Catalan has had historically pronominal uses of *meal* verbs as well, in particular for *dinar-se* 'have lunch' (17) and *desdejunar-se* 'have breakfast' (18b), as extensively shown by Cremades & Ginebra (2021a, 2021b). In fact, the prevalence of the pronominal use of *meal* verbs actually leads Cremades & Ginebra (2021b) to propose that *di(s)nar-se* 'have lunch' could have functioned as an internally caused change-of-state predicate, with the meaning *stop fasting*, as we have been proposing. Even if examples of both verbs can be found in the 19th and 20th centuries (18) and (19) respectively, nowadays only *desdejunar-se* remains, with a marked old-fashioned flavor.

- (17) 15th century; Old Catalan (*DCVB*, s.v. *dinar* and *CICA*, from Cremades & Ginebra 2021b, 2021c)

- a. E él dix: **Dinar-me** vull.
 and he say.PST.3SG have.lunch.INF=REFL.1SG want.PRS.1SG
 'And he said: I want to have lunch.'
- b. anave comprar a la place de què· s **dinàs**
 go.IPFV.3SG buy.INF to the market of what REFL DINE.SBJV.PST.3SG
 '(s)he was going to buy groceries at the market to prepare what (s)he could eat for lunch'
- c. la senyora mare sua e Joseph **se dinaren** ab sola
 the lady mother her and Joseph REFL DINE.PST.3PL with only
 fruyta e pa.
 fruit and bread
 'the lady mother and Joseph had only fruit and bread for lunch.'

- (18) Modern Catalan (*CTILC*, from Cremades & Ginebra 2021b)

- a. Dos senyors **s' estavan dinant**.
 two men REFL be.IPFV.3PL dine.GER
 'Two men were having lunch.'
- b. la seua filla major [...] **es desdejunava** amb un got
 the her daughter older REFL have.breakfast.IPFV.3SG with a glass
 de llet i dos croissants
 of milk and two croissants
 'her older daughter [...] had a glass of milk and two croissants for breakfast'

- (19) Contemporary Catalan (*DIEC2*, s.v. *desdejunar*)

- L' Àngels i jo **ens desdejunàrem** a les vuit.
 the Àngels and I REFL.1PL have.breakfast.PST.1PL at the eight
 'Àngels and I had breakfast at 8 am.'

Pronominal *meal* verbs seem to be much more anecdotal but nonetheless attested in Spanish. The *DRAE* only includes the pronominal use of *desayunar* (20), and the *DPD* explicitly refers to it as an old use still possible, even with metaphorical uses with the meaning ‘find out about something at the beginning of the day’ (20c).⁹

- (20) a. **Se desayuna** con magdalenas.
REFL have.breakfast.PRS.3SG with muffins
‘(S)he has breakfast with muffins.’
- b. **Se desayunaba** con medio litro de orujo.
REFL have.breakfast.IPFV.3SG with half liter of grape.liquor
‘(S)he had half a liter of grape liquor for breakfast.’
- c. México **se desayuna** con nuevo grupo alzado en armas.
Mexico REFL have.breakfast.PRS.3SG with new group risen in weapons
‘Mexico wakes up with a new revolted group.’

Let us briefly mention Portuguese and Italian. In the former, *de(s)jeuar* ‘have breakfast’, which is not used nowadays, could also be pronominal (Cremades & Ginebra 2021a). As for Italian, Cremades & Ginebra mention that the verb *merendare* ‘have a snack’, which is characterized as a rarely used verb in Italian dictionaries, did have an old use as pronominal, as in the following example by Boccaccio cited in one of these dictionaries.

- (21) Dove io ho veduto **merendarsi** le donne.
where I have.PRS.1SG seen have.a.snack.INF=REFL the women
‘Where I saw the women having a snack.’

The compatibility of *meal* verbs with the reflexive pronoun *se* in Old Romance suggests that historically they probably involved an unaccusative structure. In Contemporary Romance, *meal* verbs seem to have veered towards a more unergative-like structure whose subject is understood as an agentive initiator leading to a change they themselves undergo. The fact that *meal* verbs in Contemporary Romance, in contrast to Old Romance, are not compatible with the reflexive pronoun suggests that this verb class may have undergone a change regarding their syntax. This view is supported by the discussion in Massanell i Messalles (in press), who suggests that *meal* verbs probably underwent a semantic evolution whereby verbs such as *dinar* ‘have lunch’ in Catalan were historically closer to their etymological meaning of ‘stop fasting’, which appears to have been conceived of as a proper change of state.¹⁰ Massanell i Messalles (in press) further points out that when the meaning of *dinar* changed to that of ‘have the main meal of the day’, the verb then behaved more like a canonical unergative, since the meaning was not conceived of as that of ‘stop fasting’ but rather as that of an agent carrying out a volitional action of ingesting food (cf. Jerro 2019). In our view, it would not be unreasonable to suggest that *meal* verbs have

⁹It is worth mentioning that, as Cremades & Ginebra (2021a) point out, the pronominal forms *merendarse* ‘have a snack’ and *cenarse* ‘have dinner’ in Spanish are in fact attested in Cuervo’s (1998) dictionary.

¹⁰Actually, in Old Catalan the primary meaning of *dinar* referred to the first meal of the day.

probably undergone a syntactic change from a more canonical unaccusative structure in Old Romance to a hybrid syntax structure in Contemporary Romance.

Additional support for the claim that *meal* verbs probably underwent a syntactic and semantic change comes from further observing that this verb class in Old Romance selected BE for compound tenses, i.e., the auxiliary for unaccusatives entailing change of state/location (cf. Sorace 2000). We illustrate this for Old Spanish (22) and Old Catalan (23) (cf. Massanell i Messalles in press).¹¹

(22) 13th and 12th centuries respectively; *CORDE*, s.v., *cenar*, *almorzar*

- a. El día de la cena, quando **fuemos** **cenados**.
 the day of the dinner when be.PST.1PL dine.PTCP.M.PL
 'The day of the dinner, when we had had dinner.'
- b. Asur Gonçález entrava por el palacio [...] vermejo viene,
 Asur Gonçález enter.IPFV.3SG for the palace red come.PRS.3SG
 ca **era** **almorzado**.
 because be.IPFV.3SG have.lunch.PTCP.M.SG
 'Asur Gonçález arrived at the palace; his face was red, as he had had a big lunch.'

(23) 14th and 15th centuries respectively; *DCVB*, s.v. *dinar* and *CICA*

- a. no volguem parlar ab els tro que **fóssem**
 NEG want.PST.1PL talk.INF with them until that be.SBJV.PST.1PL
dinats.
 dine.PTCP.M.PL
 'we did not want to talk to them until we had had lunch.'
- b. lo Emperador se **fon** primer **dinat**.
 the Emperor REFL be.PST.3SG first dine.PTCP.M.SG
 'the Emperor had lunch first.'

Compatibility with the reflexive *se* and the fact that *meal* verbs combined with BE as the auxiliary for compound tenses in Old Romance leads Cremades & Ginebra (2021b) to suggest that *meal* verbs appear to have properties typical of unaccusative verbs, rather than canonical unergatives. However, Cremades & Ginebra also point out that *meal* verbs are not canonical unaccusative verbs either, since in Contemporary Romance, they do not allow bare post-verbal subjects (24) or *en* cliticization in Catalan (25), two hallmark properties of unaccusative verbs in a Romance language like Catalan (cf. (24b)–(25b); and see Rigau 1990, 1991, 1994; Rosselló 2008; Acedo-Matellán & Mateu 2015 for *en* cliticization in Catalan; and Rigau 1990; Mateu & Massanell i Messalles 2015 for bare post-verbal subjects).

¹¹The same is true for Old Occitan:

(i) 13th century; *Provençalisch*, s.v. *dinnar*

Can cascus **er** **dinnatz** [...] can Karles **fon** **dinnatz**
 when everyone be.FUT.3SG dine.PTCP.NOM when Karles be.PST.3SG dine.PTCP.NOM
 'When everyone will have had dinner [...] when Karles had lunch'

- (24) a. *Dinen alumnes al menjador. MEAL VERB
 dine.PRS.3PL students in.the dining.room
 ‘Some students have lunch in the dining hall.’
- b. Arriben alumnes al menjador. UNACCUSATIVE
 arrive.PRS.3PL students in.the dining.room
 ‘Some students arrive at the dining hall.’
- (25) a. *En dinen al menjador. MEAL VERB
 EN dine.PRS.3PL the dining.room
 ‘Some (people) have lunch in the dining hall.’
- b. N’ arriben al menjador. UNACCUSATIVE
 EN arrive.PRS.3PL the dining.room
 ‘Some (people) arrive at the dining hall.’

The analysis proposed in this section shares key intuitions with [Den Dikken’s \(2023\)](#) analysis of verbs of ingesting in Spanish and Hungarian, e.g., Spanish *comer* ‘eat’ and Hungarian *eszik* ‘eat’, along with the Romance clitic *se* or the Hungarian verbal marker *ik*. Den Dikken addresses the dual role of the subject of verbs of ingesting as both an agentive participant and as experiencing the event (see also [Jerro 2019](#)). Den Dikken emphasizes that the Romance clitic *se* does not have a direct aspectual influence on verbs of ingesting, i.e., it does not complete or maximalize the event as in examples such as *María se comió una manzana* ‘María ate an apple’. In this respect, *se* would be more in line with Hungarian *ik* than with the verbal particle *meg*, which is the particle used to mark completion of the event. [Den Dikken \(2023, 1\)](#) argues that both *se* and *ik* are co-indexed with the subject of these verb classes and it is therefore related to the event twice, i.e., it has properties of both internal and external arguments. Along the same lines, an anonymous reviewer notes that *meal* verbs in Hungarian apparently also feature *ik*, e.g., *reggelizik* ‘have breakfast’ or *vacsorázik* ‘have dinner’. The fact that *meal* verbs in Hungarian also feature this verbal marker naturally aligns with our proposal that the subject of *meal* verbs is thematically interpreted as both an agent/initiator and as a patient/undergoer. As discussed above, Romance *meal* verbs have generally seen the disappearance of the morpheme *se*, as the examples that we find nowadays mostly sound old-fashioned or have an archaic flavor. We have suggested that this might be the result of the fact that Romance *meal* verbs have undergone a syntactic change where they originally presented canonical properties of unaccusative verbs and nowadays have veered towards a more unergative-like syntax. In any case, the fact that *meal* verbs in typologically unrelated languages such as Hungarian feature this morpheme suggests that the phenomenon of subjects having a dual theta role may extend to a wider range of verb classes and languages.

In short, what is clear from observations made in previous works is that *meal* verbs in Romance exhibit a hybrid behavior between unergativity and unaccusativity (cf. [Massanelli & Messalles in press](#); [Cremades & Ginebra 2021a, 2021b, 2021c](#)). Their hybrid behavior has therefore consequences for the thematic interpretation of their subject: it is an argument that presents properties of both initiators and undergoers, i.e., what Cremades & Ginebra have called an *affected agent*, following [Næss \(2007\)](#). Our approach provides a natural explanation as to why *meal* verbs should generate apparently contradictory results when subjected to unergative or

unaccusative diagnostics. Namely, we have proposed that *meal* verbs in Romance involve a hybrid argument structure à la [Pineda & Berro \(2020\)](#), in which the subject is first generated in the specifier position of the Voice head and is co-indexed with the non-pronounced specifier of *v* (2). Co-indexation therefore allows their subject to be interpreted as both an initiator and as an undergoer since the subject is an argument of both Voice and *v*.

In the next section, we consider one final diagnostic that shows that the intuition that the subject of *meal* verbs is an affected agent seems to be correct, since *meal* verbs in Romance occur as resultative adjectival participles, a construction which only allows participles built on verbs that denote a result state interpretation of an internal argument ([Embick 2004](#)).

3.3. Resultative adjectival participles

Resultative adjectival participles denote a consequent result state reached after a previous event ([Kratzer 1996, 2000](#); [Anagnostopoulou 2003](#); [Embick 2004](#); [Alexiadou & Anagnostopoulou 2008](#); [Gehrke 2011](#), among many others). They are mainly compatible with verbs that involve a result state interpretation of an internal argument, that is, transitive change of state verbs and unaccusative verbs, like the English verb *open*.

(26) The door was opened.

Resultative: The door was in a state of having become open.

(example modified from [Embick 2004](#), 356)

Unergatives are generally not accepted in this configuration (27). According to [Embick \(2004\)](#), this incompatibility follows from the fact that the roots of unergative verbs cannot be associated with an internal argument (see [Embick 2004](#) for details).

(27) *John is laughed.

([Embick 2004](#), 375)

In our terms, in canonical unergatives of the *laugh* sort, the subject is introduced syntactically in the specifier of Voice (1). In order for a resultative participle to be possible, *v* must introduce an argument, and the verb must entail a result state, e.g., the *being open* in (26) above for *The door was opened*. Since in verbs with a hybrid syntactic structure the verb encodes a change of state, i.e., *stop fasting*, and *v* introduces an argument interpreted as the undergoer, we predict that resultative adjectival participles built on *meal* verbs should be possible in Romance. This prediction is indeed met, as resultative adjectival participles built on these verbs frequently occur across Romance. We illustrate this below for French (28), Spanish (29) and Catalan (30).¹²

¹²The same situation has been reported for other Romance languages. Namely, [Bentley & Ledgeway \(2014, 2015\)](#) point out that several ostensibly *unergative* verbs, such as those meaning *smoke* and *eat*, allow for resultative adjectival passives in Romance and especially in Italian varieties. This would straightforwardly follow from our account, as these verbs could potentially be characterized as hybrid verbs as well.

(28) French

Tous les élèves doivent aller à l'école bien
all the pupils must.PRS.3PL go.INF to the school well
déjeunés.

have.breakfast.PTCP.PL

'All the pupils must go to school well fed.' (Lit. go to school *well breakfasted*)

(29) Spanish

- a. Hemos venido **cenados.**
have.PRS.1PL come.PTCP dined.PTCP.M.PL
'We came after having had dinner.' (Lit. We came *dined*.) (Víctor Acedo-Matellán, p.c.)
- b. salir de su casa, vestidos, duchados
exit.INF of their house dressed.PTCP.M.PL showered.PTCP.M.PL
y **desayunados.**
and have.breakfast.PTCP.M.PL
'leave home, dressed, showered and after having had breakfast.' (Lit. leave home, dressed, showered and *breakfasted*) (CREA)
- c. Siempre los viernes que ella llegaba tenía que
always the Fridays that she arrive.IPFV.3SG have.IPFV.3SG that
almorzar sola ya que ambos **estaban almorzados.**
have.lunch.IFV alone since that both be.IPFV.3PL have.lunch.PTCP.M.PL
'On Fridays, when she arrived, she had to have lunch alone since both of them had already had lunch.' (Lit. both of them were *lunched*) (Web)

(30) Catalan

- a. A les 7:30 estic **esmorzat** i començo a caminar.
at the 7.30 be.PRS.1SG breakfast.PTCP.M.SG and start.PRS.1SG to walk.INF
'At 7.30, I have already had breakfast and I start walking.' (Lit. I am *breakfasted*) (Crespi 2021, 112)
- b. Ja estan **sopats** i han fet tots
already be.PRS.3PL dine.PTCP.M.PL and have.PRS.3PL do.PTCP all
els tallers de cuina.
the workshops of kitchen
'They have already had dinner and have completed every cuisine workshop.' (Lit. They are already *dined*) (Crespi 2021, 112)
- c. Els nins i nines ja han de venir **dinats**
the boys and girls already have.PRS.3PL of come.INF dine.PTCP.M.PL
el dissabte.
the Saturday
'On Saturday, the boys and girls have to come once they have had dinner.' (Lit. come *dined*) (Web)

Meal verbs in Romance therefore pattern like unaccusatives in being able to form resultative adjectival participles, cf. Spanish *Juan está muerto/desaparecido* ‘Juan is dead/disappeared’, in contrast to unergative verbs, which are categorically rejected as resultative adjectival participles, cf. Spanish **María está trabajada/bostezada* lit. ‘María is worked/yawned’ (Crespi 2021).¹³

In this section, we have subjected *meal verbs* in Romance to a battery of diagnostics that probe for the presence of external and internal arguments as well as prototypical properties of unergative and unaccusative verbs. We have observed that this verb class gives apparently contradictory results in this respect, since they involve an agentive subject, can take measuring direct objects and do not occur with the reflexive *se* in Contemporary Romance, therefore patterning as canonical unergatives, yet they also test positive for unaccusativity as *meal verbs* can occur as resultative adjectival participles. We have also observed that historically, *meal verbs* appear to have fit best in the unaccusative scheme, since in Old Romance, they combined with the reflexive *se* and selected BE in compound tenses, i.e., two hallmark properties of unaccusative verbs encoding change of state/location (cf. Sorace 2000). In this respect, we have suggested that it would not be unreasonable to propose that *meal verbs* in Romance have undergone a semantic and syntactic change deviating from their etymological meaning of ‘stop fasting’, which was grammatically interpreted as a proper change of state, to the more unergative-like interpretation of ‘have a meal/eat’, as discussed by Massanell i Messalles (in press). Nowadays, the picture we find in Romance is that *meal verbs* mostly behave as unergatives, since their subject is interpreted as a canonical agent which acts volitionally in consuming a meal. However, they still retain some of the unaccusative properties such as the ability to occur as resultative adjectival participles.

4. CONCLUSION

In this paper, we have described and analyzed the behavior of *meal verbs* in Romance, a verb class whose subject is interpreted as the initiator driving up the force to bring out a process of manipulating and ingesting food, therefore being the sentient argument affected by it (Jerro 2019; Den Dikken 2023). We have observed that *meal verbs* do not show consistent behavior in the diagnostics broadly used to distinguish between unergative and unaccusative verbs. In particular, we have subjected *meal verbs* to a battery of well-established diagnostics that probe for the presence of external and internal arguments as well as prototypical properties of unergative and unaccusative verbs. We have observed that this verb class generates mixed results in this respect, since they can take measuring direct objects and do not occur with the reflexive *se*, therefore patterning as canonical unergatives, yet they also test positive for unaccusativity as

¹³As an anonymous reviewer notes, *meal verbs* in English can also appear as resultative adjectival participles when modified by degree adverbs such as *well* as in *a well-dined person* (example is the reviewer’s). We want to emphasize that in Romance, *meal verbs* are licit as resultative adjectival participles without any sort of degree modifier, e.g., a Spanish example such as *Los niños están cenados* lit. ‘The kids are dined’ is perfectly natural. This is the key point we wish to capitalize on here, since ostensibly unergative verbs like *travel* in English are also possible as resultative adjectival participles if they are modified by degree adverbs as in *a well-travelled woman*. The same picture is found in Romance, e.g., in Spanish, a canonical unergative verb like *viajar* or *leer* can form resultative adjectival participles only if they are modified by degree adverbs as in *Un hombre *(muy) leído/viajado*.

meal verbs can occur as resultative adjectival participles. The results obtained suggest that *meal* verbs are best conceived of as verbs with a hybrid argument structure.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Earlier versions of this paper were previously submitted to other journals and were rejected in the second round of peer review. The reviews we got were mixed in both cases, with one being more positive than the other, which led the editors' decision to reject the paper in the second round. The published version of this paper is the revised version according to all the reviews we got previously and in the current journal. In this respect, we are grateful to all the anonymous reviewers who provided valuable feedback since their comments, suggestions, and critiques helped us improve the final version. All remaining errors are our own.

Ausensi was supported by the grants PID2022-136610NB-I00 and PID2023-150846NA-C33, funded by the MICIU/AEI/10.13039/501100011033 and by ERDF, UE. Pineda was supported by the grant PID2023-150846NA-C33 funded by MICIU/AEI/10.13039/501100011033 and by ERDF, UE, and the grant Ramón y Cajal RYC2021-031720-I for senior researchers funded by the MICIU/AEI/10.13039/501100011033 and by the European Union NextGenerationEU and the *Plan de Recuperación, Transformación y Resiliencia*.

SOURCES

- CICA = Corpus Informatitzat del Català Antic. Joan Torruella (dir.), together with Manuel Pérez Saldanya and Josep Martines. www.cica.cat.
- CREA = Corpus de Referencia del Español Actual. Real Academia Española. <http://corpus.rae.es/creanet.html>.
- CORDE = Corpus Diacrónico del Español. Real Academia Española. <https://corpus.rae.es/cordenet.html>.
- Croisade = Claude-Charles Fauriel (ed. and translator). 1837. *Histoire de la croisade contre les hérétiques albigeois écrite en vers provençaux par un poëte contemporain*. Paris: Imprimerie Royale.
- CTILC = Corpus Textual Informatitzat de la Llengua Catalana. Institut d'Estudis Catalans. <https://ctilc.iec.cat/>.
- DCVB = Antoni M. Alcover and Francesc B. Moll. 1930–1962. *Diccionari català-valencià-balear* [DCVB]. Palma de Mallorca: Moll. <https://dcvb.iec.cat>.
- DIEC2 = Diccionari de la llengua catalana. Barcelona: Institut d'Estudis Catalans. <https://dlc.iec.cat>.
- DMF = Dictionnaire du moyen français. <http://www.atilf.fr/dmf/>.
- DPD = Real Academia de la Lengua Española, Asociación de Academias de la Lengua Española. 2005. *Diccionario panhispánico de dudas*. Real Academia de la Lengua Española. <http://www.rae.es/recursos/diccionarios/dpd>.
- DRAE = Real Academia de la Lengua Española, Asociación de Academias de la Lengua Española. 2005. *Diccionario de la Real Academia de la Lengua Española*. Real Academia de la Lengua Española. <http://dle.rae.es>.
- Provençalisch = Immanuel Bekker. 1829. *Der Roman von Fierabras: Provençalisch*. Berlin: G. Reimer.
- Trésor = Trésor de la langue française informatisé. <http://atilf.atilf.fr>.

REFERENCES

- Acedo-Matellán, Víctor and Jaume Mateu. 2015. Los verbos psicológicos: Raíces especiales en estructuras corrientes. In R. Marín (ed.) *Los predicados psicológicos*. Madrid: Visor Libros. 81–109.
- Alexiadou, Artemis. 2014. The problem with internally caused change-of-state verbs. *Linguistics* 52(4). 879–909.
- Alexiadou, Artemis and Elena Anagnostopoulou. 2004. Voice morphology in the causative-inchoative alternation: Evidence for a non-unified structural analysis of unaccusatives. In A. Alexiadou, E. Anagnostopoulou and M. Everaert (eds.) *The unaccusative puzzle*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 114–136.
- Alexiadou, Artemis and Elena Anagnostopoulou. 2008. Structuring participles. In C. B. Chang and H. J. Haynie (eds.) *Proceedings of the 26th West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics*. Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Proceedings Project. 33–41.
- Alexiadou, Artemis, Elena Anagnostopoulou and Florian Schäfer. 2015. External arguments in transitivity alternations: A layering approach. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Alexiadou, Artemis and Florian Schäfer. 2011. *There*-insertion: An unaccusativity mismatch at the syntax-semantics interface. In M. B. Washburn, S. Ouwayda, C. Ouyang, B. Yin, C. Ipek, L. Marston and A. Walker (eds.) *Proceedings of the 28th West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics*. Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Proceedings Project.
- Anagnostopoulou, Elena. 2003. Participles and voice. In A. Alexiadou, M. Rathert and A. von Stechow (eds.) *Perfect explorations*. Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter. 1–36.
- Ausensi, Josep and Alessandro Bigolin. 2024. Hybrid subjects in Spanish and Catalan: Halfway between agents and patients. *Glossa: A Journal of General Linguistics* 9(1). 1–29.
- Belletti, Adriana. 1988. The case of unaccusatives. *Linguistic Inquiry* 19. 1–34.
- Belletti, Adriana. 1999. «Inversion» as focalization and related questions. *Catalan Working Papers in Linguistics* 7. 9–45.
- Bentley, Delia and Adam Ledgeway. 2014. *Manciatu siti?* Les constructions moyennes avec les participes statifs dans les variétés italo-romanes méridionales. *Langages* 194. 63–80.
- Bentley, Delia and Adam Ledgeway. 2015. Autour de la question des participes résultatifs-statifs dans les variétés romanes. In I. Mirto (ed.) *Le relazioni irresistibili: Scritti in onore di Nunzio La Fauci per il suo sessantissimo compleanno*. Pisa: ETS. 61–91.
- Bresnan, Joan. 1982. *The mental representation of grammatical relations*. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press.
- Burzio, Luigi. 1981. *Intransitive verbs and Italian auxiliaries*. Doctoral dissertation. MIT, Cambridge, MA.
- Burzio, Luigi. 1986. *Italian syntax: A government-binding approach*. Dordrecht: Reidel.
- Cifuentes Honrubia, José Luis. 1999. Bases sintácticas y bases semánticas de la inacusatividad en verbos de movimiento. *Revista de Investigación Lingüística* 2(2). 37–72.
- Copley, Bridget and Heidi Harley. 2015. A force-theoretic framework for event structure. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 38(2). 103–158.
- Cremades, Elga and Jordi Ginebra. 2021a. Els verbs d'àpats en català i en les llengües romàniques. In O.-D. Balaş and X. Montoliu (eds.) *Actes del XVIII Col·loqui Internacional de Llengua i Literatura Catalanes*. Barcelona: Institut d'Estudis Catalans. 134–146.
- Cremades, Elga and Jordi Ginebra. 2021b. Estructura sintàctica i aspectual dels verbs d'àpats en les llengües romàniques. In L. Schösler and J. Härmä (eds.) *Actes du XXIX^e Congrès International de Linguistique et de Philologie Romanes*. Strasbourg: Éditions de linguistique et de philologie. 389–400.

- Cremades, Elga and Jordi Ginebra. 2021c. Complements preposicionals amb els verbs d'apats en català antic. In J. Massot i Muntaner (ed.) *Miscel·lània Ferrando*, Vol. 2 (Estudis de Llengua i Literatura Catalanes LXXV). Barcelona: PAMSA. 219–232.
- Crespí, Isabel. 2021. Sobre alguns participis actius amb verbs de moviment. *Caplletra 70: Revista Internacional de Filologia*. 53–80.
- Cuervo, R. José. 1998. *Diccionario de construcción y régimen de la lengua castellana*. Barcelona: Herder.
- D'Alessandro, Roberta, Irene Franco and Ángel J. Gallego (eds.). 2017. *The verbal domain*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Den Dikken, Marcel. 2023. On consumption and completion. Paper presented at the International Workshop on Maximalization Strategies in the Event Domain. Debrecen: University of Debrecen.
- Embick, David. 2004. On the structure of resultative participles in English. *Linguistic Inquiry* 35(3). 355–392.
- Gehrke, Berit. 2011. Stative passives and event kinds. In I. Reich, E. Horch and D. Pauly (eds.) *Proceedings of Sinn und Bedeutung*, Vol. 15. Saarbrücken: Universaar – Saarland University Press. 241–257.
- Hale, Kenneth and Samuel J. Keyser. 1997. The limits of argument structure. In A. Mendikoetxea and M. Uribe-Etxebarria (eds.) *Theoretical issues at the morphology-syntax interface*. Bilbao: Universidad del País Vasco/Euskal Herriko Unibertsitatea. 203–230.
- Hale, Kenneth and Samuel Jay Keyser. 2002. *Prolegomenon to a theory of argument structure*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Halle, Morris and Alex Marantz. 1993. Distributed morphology and the pieces of inflection. In K. Hale and S. J. Keyser (eds.) *The view from Building 20*. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press. 111–176.
- Irwin, Patricia. 2012. *Unaccusativity at the interfaces*. Doctoral dissertation. New York University, New York, NY.
- Jerro, Kyle. 2019. Ingestive verbs, causatives, and object symmetry in Lubukusu. *Linguistic Inquiry* 50(1). 219–232.
- Koontz-Garboden, Andrew. 2009. Anticausativization. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 27(1). 77–138.
- Kratzer, Angelika. 1996. Severing the external argument from its verb. In J. Rooryck and L. Zaring (eds.) *Phrase structure and the lexicon (Studies in Natural Language and Linguistic Theory, Vol. 33)*. Dordrecht: Kluwer Academic Publishers. 109–137.
- Kratzer, Angelika. 2000. Building statives. In L. J. Conathan, J. Good, D. Kavitskaya, A. B. Wulf and A. C. L. Yu (eds.) *Proceedings of the Twenty-Sixth Annual Meeting of the Berkeley Linguistics Society*. Berkeley, CA: Berkeley Linguistics Society, University of California. 385–399.
- Kural, Murat. 2002. A four-way classification of monadic verbs. In A. Alexiadou (ed.) *Theoretical approaches to universals*. Amsterdam & Philadelphia, PA: John Benjamins. 139–163.
- Levin, Beth. 1993. *English verb classes and alternations: A preliminary investigation*. Chicago, IL & London: The University of Chicago Press.
- Levin, Beth and Malka Rappaport. 1986. The formation of adjectival passives. *Linguistic Inquiry* 17(4). 623–661.
- Levin, Beth and Malka Rappaport Hovav. 1995. *Unaccusativity: At the syntax-lexical semantics interface*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- MacDonald, Jonathan E. 2024. Eventive VPs project AspP; Stative VPs do not: Evidence from Spanish. Paper presented at NELS 54. January 26–27, 2024, MIT, Cambridge, MA.
- Marantz, Alec. 1984. *On the nature of grammatical relations*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

- Massanell i Messalles, Mar. In press. L'auxiliar dels temps de perfet. In J. Martines, M. P. Saldanya and G. Rigau (eds.) *Gramàtica del català antic*. València: Publicacions de la Universitat de València.
- Mateu, Jaume and Mar Massanell i Messalles. 2015. A constructional approach to auxiliary selection: Evidence from existential constructions. In R. Kailuweit and M. Rosemeyer (eds.) *Auxiliary selection revisited: Gradience and gradualness*. Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter. 183–212.
- Næss, Åshild. 2007. Prototypical transitivity. Amsterdam & Philadelphia, PA: John Benjamins.
- Næss, Åshild. 2011. The grammar of eating and drinking verbs. *Language and Linguistics Compass* 5(5). 413–423.
- Nash, Léa. 2020. Nonunitary structure of unergative verbs in Georgian. Manuscript. UMR 7023, CNRS, Université Paris 8.
- Öztürk, Balkız. 2020. Transitive unergatives in Pazar Laz. *Glossa: A Journal of General Linguistics* 6(1). 23.
- Perlmutter, David M. 1978. Impersonal passives and the unaccusative hypothesis. *Proceedings of the 4th Annual Meeting of the Berkeley Linguistics Society*. 157–190.
- Perlmutter, David M. 1989. Multiattachment and the unaccusative hypothesis: The perfect auxiliary in Italian. *Probus* 1(1). 63–119.
- Perlmutter, David and Paul Postal. 1984. The I-advancement exclusiveness law. In D. M. Perlmutter and C. Rosen (eds.) *Studies in relational grammar*, Vol. 2. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press. 81–125.
- Pesetsky, David and Esther Torrego. 2004. Tense, case, and the nature of syntactic categories. In J. Guéron and J. Lecarme (eds.) *The syntax of time*. Cambridge, MA & London: MIT Press. 495–538.
- Pineda, Anna and Ane Berro. 2020. Hybrid intransitives in Basque. *Glossa: A Journal of General Linguistics* 5(1). 1–28.
- Ramchand, Gillian Catrion. 2008. *Verb meaning and the lexicon: A first phase syntax*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Rappaport Hovav, Malka. 2020. Deconstructing internal causation. In E. B.-A. Siegal and N. Boneh (eds.) *Perspectives on causation: Selected papers from the Jerusalem 2017 Workshop*. Dordrecht: Springer. 219–255.
- Rappaport Hovav, Malka and Beth Levin. 1998. Building verb meanings. In M. Butt and W. Geuder (eds.) *The projection of arguments: Lexical and compositional factors*. Stanford, CA: CSLI Publications. 97–134.
- Rigau, Gemma. 1990. Les propietats d'agradar: Estructura temàtica i comportament sintàctic. *Caplletra: Revista Internacional de Filologia* 8. 7–20.
- Rigau, Gemma. 1991. On the functional properties of AGR. *Catalan Working Papers in Linguistics* 1. 235–260.
- Rigau, Gemma. 1994. Les propietats dels verbs pronominals. *Els Marges* 50. 29–39.
- Rosselló, Joana. 2008. El SV, I: Verbs i arguments verbals. In J. Solà, M. R. Lloret and J. Mascaró (eds.) *Gramàtica del català contemporani*. Barcelona: Empúries. 1853–1949.
- Schäfer, Florian. 2008. *The syntax of (anti-)causatives: External arguments in change-of-state contexts*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Solà, Joan. 1973. *Estudis de sintaxi catalana 2 (Llibres a l'Abast 105)*. Barcelona: Edicions 62.
- Sorace, Antonella. 2000. Gradients in auxiliary selection with intransitive verbs. *Language*. 859–890.
- Tenny, Carol. 1987. *Grammaticalizing aspect and affectedness*. Doctoral dissertation. MIT, Cambridge, MA.
- Tenny, Carol. 1994. *Aspectual roles and the syntax-semantics interface*. Dordrecht: Kluwer.
- Tollan, Rebecca. 2018. Unergatives are different: Two types of transitivity in Samoan. *Glossa: A Journal of General Linguistics* 3(1).

- Tollan, Rebecca and Will Oxford. 2018. Voice-less unergatives: Evidence from Algonquian. In B. W. G. Bennett, L. Hracs and D. Ryan Storoshenko (eds.) *Proceedings of the 35th West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics*. Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press. 399–408.
- Torrego, Esther. 1989. Unergative-unaccusative alternations in Spanish. In I. Laka and A. Mahajan (eds.) *Functional heads and clause structure* (MIT working papers in linguistics, Vol. 10). Cambridge, MA. 253–272.
- Wood, Jim. 2012. Icelandic morphosyntax and argument structure. Doctoral dissertation. New York University, New York, NY.